

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 321

By Reeves

A RESOLUTION to recognize and commend Davis House Child Advocacy Center on its twenty-fifth anniversary.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly take great pleasure in recognizing those estimable organizations that are devoted to improving the lives of young people in this State; and

WHEREAS, one such organization is the Davis House Child Advocacy Center in Franklin, which celebrates its twenty-fifth anniversary this year; and

WHEREAS, the organization was created in the spring of 1999 by Ronald L. Davis, a longtime district attorney general in Williamson County's 21st Judicial District, and founded as the Williamson County Child Advocacy Center Task Force; and

WHEREAS, the initiative was founded out of Mr. Davis's exasperation and great concern for vulnerable children who, at that time, even if they had the courage to report sexual or severe physical abuse, faced the compounding trauma of multiple interviews by many adults in scary, confusing places; typically, children would have to tell the story of their trauma an average of thirteen times; and

WHEREAS, after a year and a half of planning, the Williamson County Child Advocacy Center opened its doors in September of 2000; nine years later, after the passing of beloved founder Ron Davis, the center was renamed Davis House, honoring the namesake's hard work, vision, and dedication to children; and

WHEREAS, Davis House was designed to provide a safe, child-friendly place for children to come following allegations of abuse and where they, and their non-offending caregivers, could receive specific services such as forensic interviews, court advocacy, and specialized trauma therapy to help them heal from the abuse experienced; and

WHEREAS, Davis House has completed over 10,000 forensic interviews and 5,000 counseling sessions; last year alone, the center served more than 300 children, not including those whom they continued to support throughout the life of court cases and journeys toward healing; and

WHEREAS, abuse happens in every community, regardless of socioeconomic status, race, religion, education, or ethnicity; it happens in homes, neighborhoods, schools, churches, daycares, and youth sports environments. Recent studies show that one in ten children are sexually abused before their eighteenth birthday and that in ninety percent of those cases, the child knows their abuser; and

WHEREAS, through education and prevention programs, Davis House raises awareness about child abuse, signs to watch for, and preventive measures; this education helps adults in the community—including parents, teachers, and caregivers—identify potential abuse early, enabling intervention before harm escalates; and

WHEREAS, the center teaches children in the community age-appropriate lessons on topics such as safe adults, healthy boundaries, unsafe touches, internet safety, and healthy relationships, fostering a more vigilant and informed community that can better protect children; and

WHEREAS, Davis House also works closely with law enforcement, the Department of Children's Services, the district attorney's office, and other agencies involved in the Child Protective Investigative Team to create a collaborative approach to reviewing cases of child abuse, ensuring that every case receives comprehensive attention and that children are protected in a coordinated and effective way; and

WHEREAS, through its many programs, Davis House fills critical gaps in support, education, and recovery services for abuse survivors and their families, ultimately working to create a safer, more aware, and resilient community; and

WHEREAS, Davis House has been wholly devoted to helping children when they are at their most vulnerable and strengthening their community, bringing justice, treatment, and prevention to children and families in Williamson County; and

WHEREAS, it is most fitting that we recognize one of this State's most exemplary advocacy organizations at this time; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we recognize and commend the Davis House Child Advocacy Center in Franklin for its compassionate service to the children of Williamson County, extending our deepest gratitude for the center's important work and our best wishes for its continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.